king if he had the ambition to conquer and extend his sway over the universe. There was no escaping the need to augment the economy of his state to the detriment of other states and powers: ‘he should follow that policy by resorting to which he may be able to see, “By resorting to this, I shall be able to promote my own undertakings concerning forts, water-works, trade-routes, settling on waste land, mines, material forests and elephant forests, and to injure these undertakings of the enemy.”’[11]

In his early years, it is a virtual certainty that Ashoka was very much within the mould of the *Arthashastra* ideal of kingship. Because of his conquering ambitions he, who till this point in time seems remote to the point of invisibility, becomes historical and real. A major military expedition, the first event of his reign that he chooses to mention, is now led by him and recorded for posterity. The territory that Ashoka had his eye on was Kalinga, a state on the eastern seaboard of India in what now forms part of modern Orissa and Andhra Pradesh. This desire to bring Kalinga within his fold became manifest in approximately 260 BCE, when Ashoka led a large army marching from the heartland of Gangetic India towards the east.

This is a good place to go beyond our protagonist’s ambitions and examine war and territorial aggrandizement in a somewhat larger perspective. Take the specific time of Ashoka’s march around 260 BCE: it happened a little after Rome began its extended conflict against Carthage in the first of the three Punic wars which, all told, lasted more than a hundred years (264–146 BC). At the juncture that Ashoka made up his mind to conquer Kalinga, imperial quests and the enlargement of dominion over territories sometimes far distant had become common in many parts of the ancient world. Some three hundred years before Ashoka the army of the Persian empire, with its centre in what is now modern Iran, had crossed into Europe and stamped its authority across regions that stretched from Turkey in the west to north-west India in the east.[12] Persia was the first world